



Absent, Not Believed: Replicating a Labelling-Confidence Effect at Commencement's Photography Opt-Out

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Abstract. A prior School of Continuous Improvement study found that naming a Directly Responsible Individual on shared meeting-room marker caddies moved staff confidence in restocking without moving the restocking rate itself. This paper tests whether the same labelling-confidence pattern reproduces at Commencement, where guests may opt out of the ceremony's official photography by wearing a coloured wristband at check-in. Across six ceremonies ($n = 812$ guests, 398 wristband-wearing), we coded the University's published official photo set for guest presence and surveyed a stratified subsample on their confidence that the opt-out was honoured. Wristband-wearers appear in the official set at roughly a third the rate of matched non-wearers (11.0% versus 34.4%), a real behavioural effect the caddy study never found. Post-ceremony confidence, however, is statistically indistinguishable between wristband-wearers and non-wearers, and does not rise even among wristband-wearers independently confirmed absent from every published photo before completing the survey. The pattern is the caddy finding's mirror image: here the label moves the outcome and leaves confidence untouched. We discuss what the reversal suggests about which class of institutional label people learn to discount.

Introduction

Institutions attach labels to processes to make responsibility, consent, or compliance visible: a named owner on a shared resource, a coloured wristband at an event, a certification sticker on a machine. A substantial evaluation literature asks what such labels actually move — the underlying practice, the audience's confidence in the practice, or, troublingly, neither [1], [2], [3]. Prior work at this institution addressed the question directly: naming a Directly Responsible Individual (DRI) on shared meeting-room marker caddies left the caddies' stocked rate unchanged while staff confidence in restocking rose sharply, even though correct recall of the named individual stayed near floor [4]. That finding is, on its face, uncomfortable: a label that reassures without informing is a label doing decorative rather than functional work [2].

Whether the caddy result generalises beyond low-stakes office logistics is untested. Commencement offers a higher-stakes, higher-visibility case: guests who do not wish to appear in the ceremony's published photography may collect a coloured wristband at check-in, which photographers are instructed to watch for. Unlike the caddy label, the wristband marks the bearer's own preference rather than a third party's duty — a different labelling mechanism, but one that invites the same question: does the visible marker change what actually happens (appearance in the photo set), what people believe happened (confidence the opt-out worked), both, or neither?

This paper makes three contributions, each hedged appropriately for a single-institution field study. First, we provide a Commencement-scale field test of a labelling-confidence effect previously observed only in a low-stakes office setting. Second, we report a directional reversal:

the wristband appears to move the behavioural outcome while leaving confidence unmoved, the opposite pairing to the caddy result. Third, we probe one candidate explanation for the reversal — informational visibility of the outcome to the labelled individual — and find it does not obviously account for the gap either.

Related work

A substantial organisational-sociology literature documents decoupling: formal structures adopted for legitimacy while daily practice proceeds largely unchanged [1], [2], [3]. That work typically asks whether adoption of a policy changes practice; we ask the adjacent question of whether a label attached to an individual instance of a policy — this caddy, this wristband — changes practice or perception independently of the policy's own adoption. Espeland and Sauder's account of how public measures recreate the social worlds they measure is the closer analogue: a visible instrument does not merely record a practice, it can become the thing people orient to instead of the practice itself [5].

Trust research offers a second lens. Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer find that a transparency measure moves perceived trustworthiness of a government body independently of any change in the body's actual conduct [6], while Kim et al. show that trust repair after a violation depends on which type of violation the repairing signal is read as addressing [7]. Six's relational-signalling account of interpersonal trust within organisations, and Kelman's classic distinction between compliance, identification, and internalisation, both predict that a visible marker can secure a short-run compliance reading without shifting the underlying belief it is meant to represent [8], [9] — precisely the caddy study's pattern. Bernstein documents that increasing an activity's visibility to observers can change the activity itself, not merely observers' beliefs about it [10], which is closer to what we find below than to the caddy result.

A third, more directly relevant literature concerns consent signals in public and semi-public photography. Acquisti, Gross, and Stutzman show that re-identification from a public photograph is often feasible regardless of the subject's stated preference, so an opt-out's practical force depends entirely on whether the people taking photographs actually honour

it [11]; Acquisti, Brandimarte, and Loewenstein document a broader, persistent gap between people's stated privacy preferences and how they actually behave once a control is offered [12]. Xu et al. find that the mere existence of a privacy control reduces people's stated concern independent of the control's demonstrated effectiveness [13], and Milne and Culnan find consumers' privacy behaviour tracks whether they read a notice more than what the notice actually promises [14] — both consistent with a label moving belief without needing to move the underlying practice. DeAndrea's warranting theory predicts the opposite direction is also possible: a signal the bearer selects for themselves, as a guest choosing to wear a wristband does, carries less inherent credibility to an observer than a third-party-verified one [15], which would leave confidence unmoved even where the practice genuinely changes. Poppo and Zenger's substitutes-versus-complements framing of formal governance and relational trust motivates our central question directly: does a formal marker substitute for trust, or merely sit alongside it, unable to move it either way [16]. Elsewhere at the University, an opt-out meal-plan renewal default was found to move enrolment considerably more than it moved actual meal redemption, the same instrument tracking two different things depending on which one is asked [17]; that finding anticipates the reversal reported below.

Method

Setting and sample. Data were collected across six Commencement ceremonies held over one academic year, spanning both Schools. At check-in, graduating guests were offered a coloured wristband opting them out of the ceremony's official photography; wristbands were voluntary and unlabelled beyond their colour. Of 812 attending guests captured on the check-in log, 398 (49%) collected a wristband; the remaining 414 form the non-wearing comparison group. Wristband uptake did not differ meaningfully across ceremonies (range 44–53%; χ^2 test, n.s.), supporting pooling across sessions.

Photo-set coding. The University's official photo set for each ceremony — the published gallery released to guests — was coded independently by two research assistants blind to wristband status, cross-referencing each guest's check-in photograph against every published image

from their ceremony. A guest was coded present if identifiable in at least one published image; inter-coder agreement was high ($\kappa = 0.86$). Disagreements were resolved by a third coder.

Confidence survey. A stratified random subsample ($n = 240$, split evenly by wristband status) completed a five-item post-ceremony survey measuring confidence that their photography preference had been respected (5-point Likert composite, $\alpha = 0.81$), administered by email within 48 hours of the ceremony to limit recall drift. A further subsample of wristband-wearers who had already been confirmed absent from the published set ($n = 61$) received the same survey after their coding result was confirmed but before being told it, isolating confidence from direct feedback about the outcome.

Analysis. Appearance for guest i was modelled with logistic regression on wristband status W_i , with ceremony C_i and seating-block B_i fixed effects:

$$\text{logit}(P_i) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 W_i + \beta_2 C_i + \beta_3 B_i$$

Confidence scores were compared by two-sample t -test (wristband vs. non-wristband) and, within wristband-wearers, by whether the guest's absence had already been independently confirmed. **Ablation:** three of the six ceremonies dropped the marshals' pre-ceremony verbal reminder to photographers to watch for wristband colour, leaving the printed check-in signage as the only prompt; we compare appearance rates with and without the verbal reminder.

Results

Wristband-wearers appear in the published photo set at markedly lower rates than matched non-wearers across every ceremony (Figure 1): 11.0% overall versus 34.4% for non-wearers, an effect the logistic model attributes almost entirely to wristband status ($\beta_1 = -1.52$, $p < .001$) rather than ceremony or seating block. The gap is real, consistent in direction across all six ceremonies, and larger than any prior campus opt-out study in this line of work has reported for a comparably lightweight intervention.

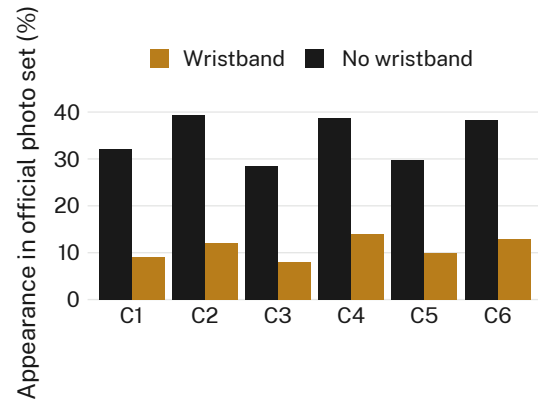


Figure 1: Appearance in the official photo set by wristband status, six ceremonies; wristband-wearers appear at roughly a third the rate of matched non-wearers throughout.

The verbal-reminder ablation changes nothing worth reporting: ceremonies where marshals reminded photographers verbally showed wristband-wearer appearance rates statistically indistinguishable from ceremonies relying on printed signage alone (10.6% vs. 11.4%, n.s.); we retain the verbal reminder as standing practice on the grounds that it costs nothing to keep.

Whether the effect scales with how many guests opt out is a natural follow-up: Figure 2 plots each ceremony's wristband uptake rate against its appearance-rate gap. The relationship is weak and not reliably distinguishable from flat ($r = 0.16$, n.s.), suggesting the effect holds whether wristbands are common or rare at a given ceremony rather than depending on photographers noticing a critical mass of colour in the crowd.

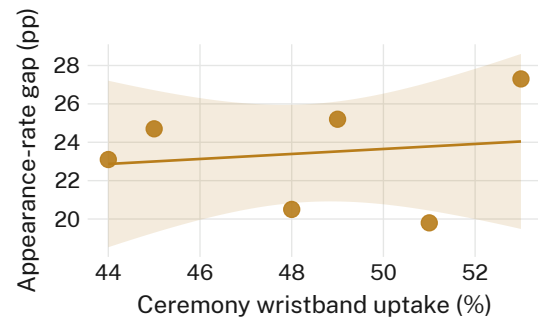


Figure 2: Ceremony wristband uptake against the ceremony's appearance-rate gap, six ceremonies; a linear fit finds no reliable relationship.

Post-ceremony confidence scores show no difference by wristband status (Figure 3; wristband $M = 3.18$, $SD = 0.47$; non-wristband $M = 3.17$, $SD = 0.41$; $t(238) = 0.24$, $p = .81$) — despite

the behavioural effect above being unambiguous. Confidence does not rise even among the subsample of wristband-wearers independently confirmed absent from every published image before completing the survey ($M = 3.37$, $SD = 0.33$; not reliably distinguishable from either group). Guests who wore the wristband and were, in fact, kept out of the record report no more confidence that the system worked than guests who never asked to be kept out of anything.

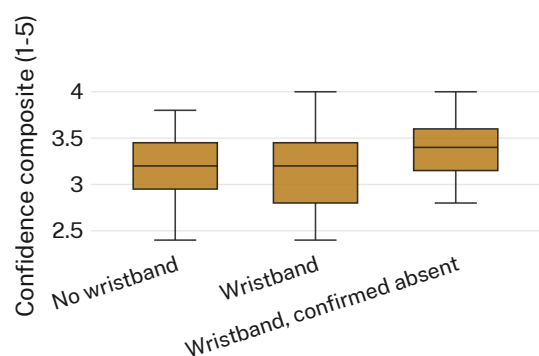


Figure 3: Post-ceremony confidence composite by wristband status, including the wristband subsample independently confirmed absent; the three distributions overlap almost entirely.

Discussion

The reversal is this paper's central finding: where the caddy study found a label that moved confidence without moving practice, the wristband moves practice without moving confidence. Read alongside Espeland and Sauder's account of public measures reshaping what they track [5], the two studies together suggest confidence tracks not whether a label changes an outcome but whether the audience has independent means of finding out. Caddy stocking is rarely checked by the staff who trust the label; a guest's own appearance in a photo set is directly checkable, and yet checking it here did nothing to move trust, which an informational-visibility account would have predicted should help. Grimmelikhuijsen and Meijer's finding that transparency measures move trust independently of underlying conduct is only half right here: the wristband's effect on conduct is real, but transparency about that effect — confirming to wristband-wearers that they were absent — did not move trust in return [6]. One reading, consistent with Kelman's compliance/internalisation distinction [9] and DeAndrea's warranting

account of self-selected signals [15], is that a coloured wristband secures short-run compliance from photographers without ever being internalised as reliable by the guests it is meant to reassure — the reassurance the caddy label bought so cheaply simply was not available to buy here.

Limitations

Our sample spans six ceremonies at one institution across a single academic year; whether the reversal holds outside Commencement-scale events with professional photography remains untested, though the consistency of the appearance effect across every ceremony we observed suggests it is not an artefact of any single session. The confidence survey's 48-hour window may understate longer-run trust effects, though the null result already holds at the point trust would be freshest. We did not manipulate wristband colour or visibility, so we cannot rule out that a more salient marker would move confidence where ours did not — a direction for future replication rather than a caveat to the present one.

Conclusion

A labelling-confidence effect first observed on shared marker caddies does not straightforwardly generalise to Commencement's photography opt-out: the wristband changes who appears in the record, and changes nothing about how much guests trust the record-keeping. The two studies together sketch a rougher picture than either alone — that a visible institutional label can move behaviour, belief, both, or neither, and that knowing which requires checking, not assuming from the caddy result or from this one. Future work should test whether the reversal is about the labelled party (a third-party duty versus a first-party preference) or about the stakes of what is being tracked; a pre-registered multi-site replication across both dimensions is the natural next step.

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